

City Air Makes You Free

(Cities and Freedom/Agency)

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We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places. But overall it is a mix and varies by region and country. East Asia/Pacific stands out with high effect sizes at about .4 or even .5, also controlling for other predictors of freedom. South Asia stands out as having large positive effect .3-.4 in the smallest category ($< 2k$). In particular in many regions or countries there is more freedom v large cities $> 500k$ in large towns midsize cities of $100 - 500k$ and $50 - 100k$ but slightly less in the smallest places $< 2k$. The effect sizes are large of about 4 steps on 1-10 income scale.

City air makes you free (Stadt Luft macht frei) (Park et al. [1925] 1984, p. 12) originated in the Middle Ages, and it meant freedom from feudalism in cities, non-feudal islands in a sea of feudalism (Harvey 2012).

The parallel is somewhat a stretch (and the title is hook bait). The original saying was in Middle ages and referred to freedom from feudalism in cities. Feudalism is long gone, although we may have techno feudalism (cite), but the idea does remain that cities are still more free than ruralities, especially for non-conformist types such as LGBTQ.

We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places.

1 Data

We use World Bank regions classification:

- East Asia/Pacific: AUS, CHN, HKG, IDN, JPN, KOR, MAC, MMR, MNG, MYS, NZL, PHL, SGP, THA, and VNM.
- Europe/Central Asia: AND, ARM, CYP, CZE, DEU, GBR, GRC, KAZ, KGZ, NLD, ROU, RUS, SRB, SVK, TJK, TUR, and UKR.
- Latin America/Caribbean: ARG, BOL, BRA, CHL, COL, ECU, GTM, MEX, NIC, PER, PRI, URY, and VEN.
- Middle East/North Africa: EGY IRN IRQ JOR LBN LBY MAR TUN.
- North America: CAN and USA.
- South Asia: BGD, MDV, and PAK.
- Sub-Saharan Africa: ETH, KEN, NGA, and ZWE.

2 Results

First for all regions in general there is more freedom in smaller areas v top bin, the base case ($> 500k$) in table 1 but controlling for other predictors in table 2 it is just the 2nd (100-500k) and 3rd (50-100k) largest categories, and smaller values in the middle or insignificant; and indeed negative -.07 for the smallest areas ($< 2k$). Next we separate by region.

East Asia/Pacific stands out with high effect sizes at about .4 or even .5, also controlling for other predictors of freedom. Europe flips from some positive effects without controls to negative with controls. Latin America/Caribbean stands out with negative effect in the very smallest areas. Middle East/North Africa has mostly negative effects. North America is positive in 2nd largest category (100-500k). South Asia stands out as having large positive effect .3-.4 in the smallest category ($< 2k$). Sub-Saharan Africa doesn't show a significant differences.

	All	East Asia/Pacific	Europe/Centra Asia	Latin Amer-ica/Caribbean	Middle East/North Africa	North Amer-ica	South Asia	Sub-Saharan Africa
town==<2k	-0.03	0.05	-0.05	-0.28***	0.22	-0.07	0.39**	-0.29
town==2-5k	0.10***	0.36***	0.17**	-0.13	-0.09	-0.07	0.31*	0.06
town==5-10k	0.18***	0.51***	0.11+	-0.01	-0.12	0.13	0.26+	0.35
town==10-20k	0.04	0.52***	-0.07	0.07	-0.34***	-0.03	0.06	0.19
town==20-50k	0.15***	0.28***	0.16**	0.08	-0.17*	0.09	0.13	-0.22
town==50-100k	0.14***	0.41***	-0.02	0.04	-0.02	0.12	-0.18	-0.06
town==100-500k	0.15***	0.55***	-0.05	-0.08+	-0.27***	0.18**	0.36*	-0.45+
constant	7.12***	6.76***	6.98***	7.85***	6.88***	7.44***	7.41***	7.14***
N	92216	24560	24103	17285	9846	5833	4226	4694

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; ro-
bust std err

Table 1: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

	All	East Asia/Pacific	Europe/Centra Asia	Latin Amer-ica/Caribbean	Middle East/North Africa	North Amer-ica	South Asia	Sub-Saharan Africa
town==<2k	-0.07*	0.01	-0.02	-0.16*	-0.00	-0.06	0.30*	-0.02
town==2-5k	0.02	0.30***	0.00	-0.13	-0.13	-0.10	0.25+	0.25
town==5-10k	0.08*	0.37***	0.04	-0.03	-0.17*	-0.03	0.18	0.44+
town==10-20k	-0.00	0.42***	-0.19**	-0.00	-0.33***	-0.02	0.17	0.24
town==20-50k	0.06*	0.24***	-0.02	-0.01	-0.22**	0.05	-0.12	-0.08
town==50-100k	0.12***	0.35***	-0.21***	0.00	-0.02	0.13+	-0.42	0.11
town==100-500k	0.13***	0.51***	-0.19***	-0.03	-0.28***	0.13*	0.27	-0.37
trust	-0.06***	0.06*	0.04	-0.12*	-0.07	0.15***	-0.06	-0.80***
age	0.01*	0.01*	0.00	0.02**	-0.00	0.03**	0.05**	0.02
age2	-0.00**	-0.00*	-0.00	-0.00*	0.00	-0.00**	-0.00*	-0.00
male	0.02	-0.08**	0.04	-0.08*	0.23***	-0.13**	0.05	0.15+
married or living together as married	-0.09***	-0.01	-0.08*	-0.06	0.01	-0.03	0.09	0.23*
Full time	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Part time	-0.07**	-0.03	-0.05	-0.24***	-0.06	0.10	-0.17	-0.01
Self employed	0.01	-0.12**	0.04	-0.06	-0.05	0.33***	-0.38***	0.20
Retired	0.04	0.15**	-0.09	0.07	0.34**	-0.04	-0.10	-0.17
Housewife	-0.12***	-0.16**	-0.18**	-0.07	-0.11	-0.03	-0.44***	0.02
Students	-0.19***	-0.21**	-0.02	-0.29***	-0.20+	0.08	-0.18	-0.07
Unemployed	0.01	-0.09	-0.13+	-0.04	-0.11	-0.07	-0.02	0.22
Other	0.06	-0.29+	-0.20	0.06	-0.11	0.00	-2.05*	1.40**
class	-0.01	-0.05**	0.10***	-0.00	-0.09**	-0.04	-0.04	0.09*
income	0.03***	0.04***	0.01	0.01	0.06***	0.05*	0.01	0.03
financial satisfac-tion	0.26***	0.30***	0.29***	0.19***	0.29***	0.25***	0.30***	0.09***
health	0.35***	0.31***	0.25***	0.37***	0.46***	0.50***	0.20***	0.24***
How many children do you have	0.07***	-0.01	0.05***	0.02	0.10***	0.06**	-0.02	-0.08**
religion important	0.05***	0.08***	0.02	0.03+	0.35***	0.10***	0.14	0.21+
Member: Belong to education, arts, music or cultural activities	0.01	-0.03	-0.08	-0.02	0.11	-0.03	-0.00	0.14
Member: Belong to sports or recreation	-0.06**	0.00	-0.02	-0.15**	0.04	-0.06	-0.36**	-0.13
Active/Inactive membership of church or religious organization	0.11***	0.06**	-0.07*	-0.03	0.13**	-0.02	-0.14*	0.10
constant	3.83***	3.25***	4.07***	4.82***	1.91***	2.94***	3.24***	3.82***
N	81093	22574	18548	15903	9037	5728	3654	4442

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; ro-
bust std err

Table 2: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

in table 3 overall it is a mix some countries one way some another TODO describe in detail! and relate to regions from earlier!!

	town==2k	town==5k	town==10k	town==20k	town==50k	town==100k	town==500k	N
AND	-0.59+	0.13	0.09	-0.65*	0.00	0.00	0.00	869
ARG	-0.94*	-1.01*	0.49	0.30	-0.73	-0.34	-0.11	768
ARM	0.11	-0.09	0.42	0.30	0.03	0.00	-0.30	1139
AUS	0.26	0.16	0.02	-0.01	0.09	0.17	-0.09	1505
BGD	-0.75	-0.32	-0.36	-0.56	-0.67	-0.94	0.00	1167
BOL	-0.17	-0.15	-0.53*	-0.16	-0.34*	-0.17	-0.11	1859
BRA	-0.31	0.06	-0.55	-0.28	-0.22	0.09	-0.08	1477
CAN	0.08	0.02	0.09	0.09	0.01	0.11	0.12+	4018
CHL	-0.24	0.06	0.00	-1.58*	-0.81*	-0.40	-0.39*	855
CHN	0.00	0.00	0.00	-0.23	-0.27*	-0.10	0.00	2720
COL	-0.16	0.08	0.30	-0.12	0.29	-0.05	0.01	1520
CYP	-0.41	-0.56*	-0.79*	-0.55	-0.06	-0.39	0.00	800
CZE	0.18	-0.50*	0.11	-0.55*	0.10	-0.25	-0.20	1156
DEU	0.20	0.29	0.00	0.25	0.31+	-0.01	0.44*	1378
ECU	0.31	-0.15	0.10	0.38	0.13	-0.21	0.11	1121
EGY	0.00	-0.11	0.22	0.00	0.08	0.39+	-0.19	1088
ETH	-1.63*	-0.86	-0.77	-1.14+	-1.30+	-1.25+	-2.45*	1191
GRC	0.02	-0.27	-0.29	0.22	0.08	0.09	0.10	1091
GTM	0.00	1.10*	-0.91	0.18	-0.08	0.09	0.00	1074
HKG	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	2026
IDN	0.38	0.36	0.20	0.23	0.42	0.70*	0.10	3084
IRN	0.25	0.22	0.28	0.03	0.18	0.50*	-0.01	1452
IRQ	0.00	0.09	-0.07	-0.11	0.06	0.00	-0.47*	1113
JOR	0.36	-0.21	0.29	-0.32	0.37	0.04	-0.21	1131
JPN	0.00	-1.78*	0.00	-0.22	-0.09	-0.60*	-0.29*	966
KAZ	-0.22	-0.71*	-0.36	-0.75*	-0.06	-0.40	-0.47*	941
KEN	-0.50	0.36	-0.44	-0.59	-0.33	0.56	-0.13	928
KGZ	0.19	-0.25	-0.55+	-0.03	-0.36	0.28	0.17	1075
KOR	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	-0.03	-0.06	1245
LBN	-1.10*	-0.19	-0.63*	-0.88*	-0.44*	0.05	-0.96*	1200
LBY	0.01	0.23	0.16	-0.01	-0.31	-0.60*	-0.26	865
MAC	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	744
MAR	0.37	0.30	0.61*	0.52*	0.16	0.32	0.31*	1200
MDV	0.30+	0.19	-0.20	0.74*	0.47	0.00	0.00	951
MEX	-0.11	-0.26	-0.03	-0.09	0.13	-0.16	-0.11	1587
MMR	-0.22	-0.52	-0.40	-0.18	0.00	0.00	0.00	1200
MNG	-0.01	-0.06	0.92*	0.00	0.57*	0.00	0.06	1633
MYS	-0.46*	-0.24	-0.08	-0.24	-0.17	-0.17	-0.02	1312
NGA	0.54	0.92	0.90	1.66*	0.65	0.54	-0.04	1153
NIC	0.00	0.79*	-0.34	-0.64*	-0.36	-0.09	-0.02	1200
NLD	0.00	0.33	-0.73	0.23	-0.17	-0.14	0.04	1253
NZL	0.21	0.00	0.13	-0.14	0.24	0.17	-0.21	658
PAK	-0.17	0.17	0.23	1.59*	-0.49	2.42*	-0.13	1536
PER	-0.44*	-0.88*	-1.16+	-0.90*	-0.36	-0.44*	-0.21	1331
PHL	-0.65+	-0.22	-0.51	0.01	-0.53	0.00	0.00	1195
PRI	0.00	0.00	0.00	-0.09	-0.23	-0.08	0.00	1039
ROU	0.29	0.78*	0.70*	0.73*	0.40	0.51	0.66*	968
RUS	-0.01	0.44	0.04	-1.00*	0.02	-0.14	0.02	1473
SGP	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	1884
SRB	-0.04	-0.07	0.00	-1.27*	-0.19	-0.33	-0.23	913
SVK	0.12	0.27	0.21	-0.16	0.12	0.50*	0.00	1121
THA	1.31*	1.43*	1.27*	2.05*	1.21*	1.10+	2.61*	1202
TJK	-0.46+	-0.58*	-1.50*	-0.68*	-0.47	-0.49+	-0.75*	1200
TUN	1.38*	0.11	-0.00	-0.46	0.65+	0.32	0.20	988
TUR	-0.75*	0.02	-0.38	-0.72+	-0.19	-0.66*	-0.47*	2193
TWN	0.00	0.00	0.00	1.02	0.83	0.82	0.91	1207
UKR	-0.08	-0.14	-0.06	0.16	-0.20	0.09	0.30	978
URY	0.23	-0.06	-0.13	-0.24	0.12	0.00	0.49+	885
USA	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	-0.23+	0.02	-0.04	1710
VEN	1.73*	-0.41	-0.03	0.32	-0.49*	-0.46+	-0.06	1187
VNM	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.09	0.32*	1200
ZWE	-0.03	-0.19	0.28	-1.07	-0.55	-0.74	0.00	1170

+ 0.10 * 0.05 ** 0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 3: OLS regressions of freedom/agency using model ??

3 Discussion and Conclusion

We test hypothesis that cities are more free, and we do not find support for it except in Middle East/North Africa. If anything, there is some support of the contrary—greater freedom/autonomy in smaller places. But overall it is a mix and varies byt region and country. An interesting nuance is lower freedom for the smallest places < 2k in Latin America/Caribbean. In particular in many regions or countries there is more freedom v large cities > 500k in large towns midsize cities of 100 – 500k and 50 – 100k but slightly less in the smallest places < 2k. The effect sizes are large of about 4 steps on 1-10 income scale.

Like in Okulicz-Kozaryn (2024) urbanittes probably actually have in a way fuller and more free life, but perhaps they realize more that they miss out relatively to other urbanites, and so they feel relatively less free. One mechanism could be that people tend to

compare upwards (Frey and Stutzer 2002) and there are more people to compare to in urban areas, inequality ladders are taller and the pond is bigger—often it feels better to be big fish in a small pond (rural area).

ONLINE APPENDIX

[note: this section will NOT be a part of the final version of the manuscript, but will be available online instead]

fig 1 and 2

weird to think that more ineq and pov would produce more freedom/autonomy; rather i guess lax capitalist friendly regulation would produce more ineq and pov, but should also produce less autonomy/freedom on avg, but it doesn't, there is positive relationship

or maybe the other way round: more freedom/autonomy more ineq and pov

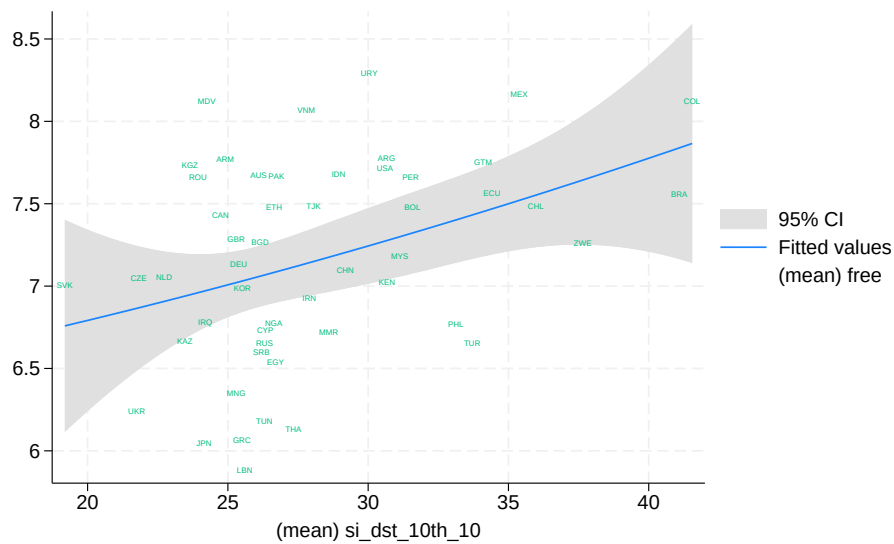


Figure 1: more ineq (inc share held by top 10perc, more autonomy—conservatives would like it!! and pretty strong corr .4

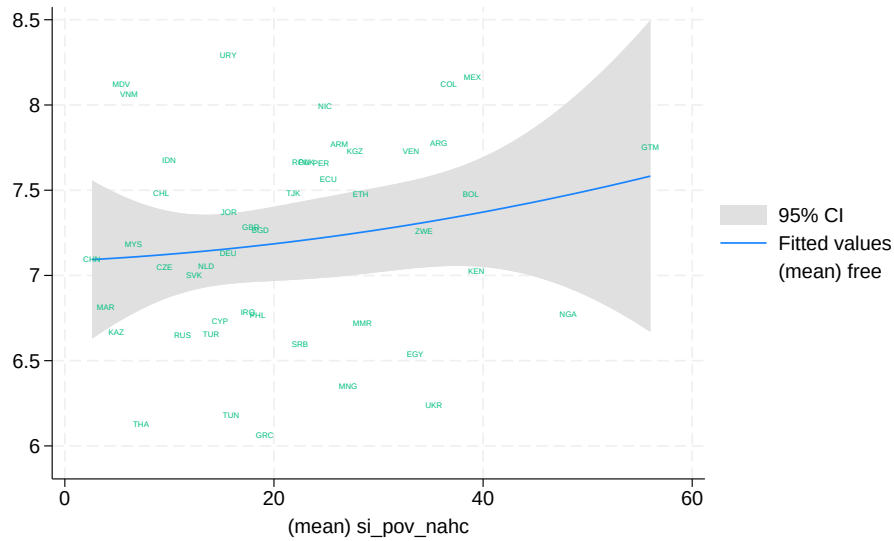


Figure 2: likewise with poverty, but here corr just .2

in table 4 we conduct additional robustness checks, a1 and a2 are repeated from the body; a1a and a2a include region dummies: in a1a 100 – 500k results are attenuated, but others are stronger; and in a2a the top three categories spanning 20 – 500k are weaker but other categories are stronger and the smaller category < 2k positive effect goes away. But then in a1b and a2b addition of country dummies kills the effects unfortunately.

	a1	a1a	a1b	a2	a2a	a2b
town==<2k	-0.03	-0.02	-0.08*	-0.07*	-0.01	-0.05
town==2-5k	0.10***	0.17***	-0.04	0.02	0.11***	-0.03
town==5-10k	0.18***	0.23***	0.01	0.08*	0.14***	0.01
town==10-20k	0.04	0.11***	-0.12***	-0.00	0.05	-0.08*
town==20-50k	0.15***	0.15***	-0.02	0.06*	0.04+	-0.04
town==50-100k	0.14***	0.15***	0.00	0.12***	0.08**	0.01
town==100-500k	0.15***	0.11***	-0.01	0.13***	0.08***	-0.02
trust				-0.06***	0.02	0.04*
age				0.01*	0.01***	0.02***
age2				-0.00**	-0.00***	-0.00***
male				0.02	-0.01	0.01
married or living together as married				-0.09***	-0.02	-0.01
Full time				0.00	0.00	0.00
Part time				-0.07**	-0.08**	-0.07*
Self employed				0.01	-0.06*	-0.01
Retired				0.04	0.01	-0.03
Housewife				-0.12***	-0.18***	-0.16***
Students				-0.19***	-0.21***	-0.13***
Unemployed				0.01	-0.07*	-0.07*
Other				0.06	-0.10	-0.13+
class				-0.01	0.01	0.02+
income				0.03***	0.03***	0.03***
financial satisfaction				0.26***	0.25***	0.24***
health				0.35***	0.34***	0.34***
How many children do you have				0.07***	0.04***	0.02*
religion important				0.05***	0.06***	0.03***
Member: Belong to education, arts, music or cultural activities				0.01	-0.01	-0.01
Member: Belong to sports or recreation				-0.06**	-0.06**	-0.06**
Active/Inactive membership of church or religious organization				0.11***	0.01	0.01
region dummies	no	yes	no	no	yes	no
country dummies	no	no	yes	no	no	yes
constant	7.12***	6.92***	7.56***	3.83***	3.45***	3.86***
N	92216	90547	92216	81093	79886	81093

+ 0.10 * 0.05 **
0.01 *** 0.001; robust std err

Table 4: OLS regressions of freedom/agency

```
. tabstat ls, by(lwd7) stat(mean sd) format(%9.1f)
```

Summary for variables: ls
Group variable: lwd7 (RECODE of lwd (do what you like))

lwd7	Mean	SD
0-4	5.6	2.7
2	7.6	2.3
3	7.6	1.8
4	8.0	1.5
5	7.8	1.9
6	8.2	1.5
7	8.9	1.5
Total	8.3	1.9

.9

References

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